

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN CZECHIA

Complete Community Opposition How-To

This guide is built around Czechia's distinctive lever — a protective limit or line that a government drew and can be held to, defended by a determined town, sustained endurance, and a national movement — and it names the tools you'll meet (the mining limits, the permit and EIA, the courts and EU environmental law, the climate frame) in plain words the first time.

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

In the coal country of North Bohemia, whole towns had been demolished under communism to feed the open-pit lignite mines; the historic old town of **Most** was razed for the coal beneath it. To stop that, the first democratic government drew protective lines in **1991 — the "mining limits"** — beyond which the excavators could not go, a guarantee to the surviving communities that they had a future. But a powerful coal company, and governments tempted by the coal, pushed to breach those limits at the **■SA mine** and dig out the hundreds of millions of tonnes of coal beneath the town of **Horní Ji■etín** and the hamlet of **■ernice** — which would have meant demolishing them and moving their people. The town refused. Led by its mayor, joined by environmentalists and a national movement whose very name declared **"we are the limits,"** the people of Horní Ji■etín fought for some **twenty years** to hold the line. And they held it: the government, facing a united nation, chose to keep the limits. The town still stands, and the coal stays in the ground beneath it.

The town of Horní Ji■etín and the "we are the limits" movement drew on tools available to communities across Czechia. The distinctive one is a **protective limit or line** — like the 1991 mining limits — a government promise a community can invoke and defend, holding the state to its own word. A project needs a **permit and EIA**, open to objection. The **courts and the EU environmental framework** are real levers. And the **climate frame** now makes keeping coal in the ground a national and global cause; protest, petition, and litigation are lawful. The decisive task is to make **keeping the promise the politically easier and more honourable course** — rousing the public, invoking the guarantee, and raising the cost of breaking it, so the government that must choose cannot afford to be the one that dug up a town; a town's determined refusal, and at the extreme its residents' refusal to leave, gives that stand its force. But these tools have real limits, and this guide states them plainly. A protective limit is a **promise a later government can break**, and holding it took the better part of **twenty years** of relentless effort — a united town, a national movement, and unbroken endurance, sustained across changing governments and the constant pressure of a coal company that never gave up. So treat a protective limit not as a guarantee but as a **line to be defended** — powerful when a movement gives it force, vulnerable when left to the state alone.

The Whole Strategy in One Idea

A big project looks unstoppable, but it's a chain of approvals and promises, and a chain breaks at its weakest link. A Czech project may run into a **protective limit** a government drew; it needs its **permit and EIA**; it can be challenged in the **courts and under EU law**; and it can be met by a **town's refusal** and a **national movement**. Every one of those is a link you can grab — and a protective limit, defended, is the one that saved Horní Ji■etín. **Find the one closest to your hand and pull.**

Be Honest About Which Fight You're In

Before you spend a year — or twenty — on this, work out your real situation:

- **If a protective limit or line exists, holding the government to that promise is your sharpest lever** — the mining limits saved a town.
- **If the permit or EIA is defective, the courts and EU law are real grounds.**
- **If your town faces erasure, its determined, united refusal is a powerful stand** — a government cannot easily be the one that dug up a town.
- **If a powerful company and a tempted government push, expect a long fight** — rouse the nation, invoke the guarantee, and raise the cost of breaking it, over years.

Read the whole guide once before you move. Two habits run through it: **invoke and defend the protective limit, and make keeping the promise the easier course** — the mining-limits template — and **build a united town and a national movement for the long endurance**, because a promise is only as strong as the movement that holds the state to it. That's how Horní Jiřetín held the line.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

To break the chain you have to see it — who decides, how a project moves, and who's watching.

Who Actually Decides

The **government** sets the big decisions — the **mining limits and other protective lines**, the energy policy, the strategic approvals — and can be moved by public pressure, the courts, and the vote. A project needs a **permit and EIA** from the environment and planning authorities. **EU environmental law** and Natura 2000 constrain projects that affect protected sites. And the **courts** review the legality of decisions. Know which decision — or which protective limit — you can reach, and aim there.

How a Project Moves — and Where You Jump In

The protective limit. A project may need a **limit breached** to proceed. *Your opening — the decisive one:* invoke and defend the limit, and hold the government to its promise.

The permit and EIA. The project needs its permit and assessment. *Your opening:* object, and attack the assessment's flaws in the courts and under EU law.

The town and the nation. *Your opening:* a **town's determined refusal** and a **national movement** that make breaking the promise politically unaffordable.

Follow the Money and the Permissions

Dig up three things. **Who's behind it and who owns them** — the coal or development company, and the governments tempted by it. **Whether a protective limit stands in its way** — because holding that limit is your strongest lever. **What it still needs** — the permit, the EIA, the limit breached: whatever's missing is the soft spot.

Who's Supposed to Be Watching

Each is an ally or an arena. The **government** holds — or breaks — the protective limit. The **environment and planning authorities** run the permit and EIA. The **courts and the European Commission** enforce the law. And Czechia's **town leaders (mayors), environmental organisations, national movements, and a**

free press are the forces that reach furthest — the united nation that held the mining limits.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Size up the odds honestly. These are rough patterns, not promises. What most moves them: whether a protective limit can be invoked, whether the town holds, and whether the nation can be roused.

What you do	Roughly works	How long	Cost	What "works" means
Just gather documents	5–10%	weeks	low	The base for everything else
Objections in the EIA	15–35%	during assessment	low	On record; conditions or a redo
Invoke and defend a protective limit	40–65%	years	low	The government held to its promise (limits)
Court challenge / EU environmental law	30–55%	months–2 yr	mod	Permit quashed; standard enforced
A town's determined, united refusal	35–60%	years	low	A government can't be the one that razed a town
National movement + climate frame	35–60%	months–yr	low	The cost of breaking the promise raised
Everything together (protective limit, town holds, nation roused)	45–70%	years	mod	Project stopped, limit held, town saved
Everything together (no limit, powerful company)	20–45%	years	mod	Delayed; contested; sometimes stopped

The lever that moves the needle most is **invoking and defending a protective limit** — holding the government to its own promise — backed by a united town, a national movement, and the climate frame. Horní Jiřetín shows the ceiling (a town saved, the coal left in the ground) and the honest floor (a promise a government could break, held only by twenty years of endurance). So aim for a project stopped, a limit held, a town saved, and delay — and defend the line.

On cost: objecting, organising, and invoking the limit are cheap; the strength is a united town, a national movement, and endurance, not money. The great requirement is to make keeping the promise the easier course — by rousing the nation and raising the cost of breaking it — and to sustain that pressure for years.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Being against "the project" is weak. Being specific — this protective limit, this defective permit, this threatened town — is strong. Answer five questions in writing.

1. What is it, and who's behind it? Name the project, the coal or development company, and the governments behind it.

2. Where is it, and what does it touch? Map it over **towns, villages, land, air, and protected sites** — and, above all, any **protective limit or line** it needs to breach. **A protective limit a government drew is your sharpest lever.**

3. What stage is it at, and what's the next deadline? Is a limit under pressure? Is the EIA in objection? Has the permit issued (opening the courts)? These openings are time-bound.

4. Does it require a promise to be broken? If it needs a government to breach a limit it drew, that betrayal is your rallying cry.

5. Will the town hold, and can the nation be roused? The town's people and mayor, environmental organisations, and a national movement. Horní Jiřetín held because its town and its nation stood together.

What this looks like in real life. A coal or development company presses a government to breach a protective limit and dig out (or build over) a town. The five questions yield: a company and tempted governments; a protective limit and a threatened town at stake (the levers); a limit under pressure and an EIA in process; a promise about to be broken; and a town and nation to rouse. That's the Horní Jiřetín pattern — invoke and defend the limit, hold the town, and rouse the nation.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION

The difference between a community that can fight and one that can't is proof. Build it in three layers.

Layer one: the protective limit and the promise. Document the **protective limit or line** and the **government's promise** behind it — when it was drawn, to whom, and why — and the record of the pressure to breach it. This is the heart of a Czech case: a promise you can hold the government to.

Layer two: the paper trail and the harm. Get the permit, the EIA, the strategic approvals, and the company's plans, and document the harm — the town or land to be destroyed, the air, the climate cost. Read the EIA for flaws.

Layer three: the map of the limit and the harm. Lay the project over the protective limit and the threatened town, so the promise to be broken and the harm are undeniable. Walking into the government, the courts, or the nation with the limit, the promise, and that map is what makes them act.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

- **The protective limit and the government's promise** — when it was drawn, to whom, and why.
- **The permit, the EIA, the strategic approvals, the company's plans** — from the environment and planning authorities.
- **The record of the pressure to breach the limit** — the company's and governments' moves.
- **The limit-and-harm map** — the protective limit and the threatened town, laid over the project.
- **Named testimony** — of the town's people and its mayor.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION

Documents give you a case; a united town and a national movement give you power — the Horní Jiřetín model. Build in four moves.

Start with a united town and its leaders. Horní Jiřetín's strength was a town united behind its mayor, refusing to be moved. Build that unity, with the town's leaders at the front — a united community facing erasure is a powerful, sympathetic stand.

Invoke the limit and the broken promise. Frame the fight around the **protective limit** and the government's **promise** to keep it — so a government that breaches it is not merely approving a mine but **breaking its word to a community and betraying a national guarantee**.

Build a national movement and the climate frame. Horní Jiřetín drew in a national movement — "we are the limits" — and the fight to keep coal in the ground is now a **climate cause**, national and global. Build that movement, and use the climate frame to raise the cost of breaking the promise.

Build to last — for twenty years if need be. Czech fights over a limit run across changing governments and a company that never quits. Build clear roles, a secure archive, a way to decide together, a plan for the long toll, and the endurance to hold the line year after year, making keeping the promise the easier course each time the government must choose.

STEP 4: LEGAL CHALLENGES

Czechia's sharpest levers are the protective limit, the courts and EU law, and the town's refusal.

The Protective Limit — Holding the Government to Its Promise

The route that saved Horní Jiřetín: invoke the **protective limit** the government drew, and hold the government to that **promise**. Make keeping it the politically easier and more honourable course — by rousing the public, invoking the guarantee, and raising the cost of breaking it — so the government cannot afford to be the one that dug up a town. This is Czechia's most powerful and distinctive lever, but it depends on a movement to give the promise force.

The Permit, the EIA, and the Courts

Object in the **EIA**, and challenge a defective **permit** in the **courts** and under the **EU environmental framework** (including Natura 2000 and a complaint to the European Commission where EU law is breached). These build the record, buy time, and add legal weight.

The Town's Refusal

A **town's determined, united refusal** — and, at the extreme, its people's refusal to leave — is a powerful moral and political stand that a government finds hard to override, because being the one who razed a town is a cost few will pay.

The Honest Limits

Straight talk: the protective limit, the courts, and the town's refusal are powerful, but a limit is a promise a government can break, and holding it took twenty years of endurance. So use the strong tools — the protective limit, the courts and EU law, the town's refusal, the national movement and climate frame — sustain the pressure, and count a project stopped, a limit held, a town saved, and delay as wins, defending the line year after year.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

A stack of documents wins nothing until you aim it.

A limit becomes a promise the government must keep. Not "we oppose the mine" but "*the government drew this limit as a guarantee to our town — and it must not break its word.*"

A town becomes an unpayable cost. *"To proceed, they must demolish a living town and move its people — no government should want to be the one that did that."*

A defective permit becomes a challenge. *"The EIA understated the harm, and EU law protects this — the permit is unsound."*

Coal becomes a climate cause. *"Keeping this coal in the ground is a national and global climate duty."*

Match it to the venue: the limit and the promise to the government and the nation; the town's refusal to the public; the defective permit to the courts and the European Commission; the climate frame to the national movement.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

In Czechia, the nation's attention is a decisive lever — a threatened town, a broken promise, and the climate cause can rouse the country, as they roused it for the mining limits. A free press and a national movement make the media front central.

Lead with the town and the promise, not procedure. Not "the EIA was deficient" but "a living town, 750 years old, marked to be dug up for coal — and a government about to break the promise that protected it." Use your strongest material: the human story of the town, the protective limit, dated photographs, and the climate cost.

Work several audiences at once. Local and national press rouse the nation and raise the cost of breaking the promise; the climate frame reaches a global audience; the town's human story moves everyone. Make it easy: captioned photos, accurate summaries, a map, strong interviews.

Two hard rules. Accuracy above all — one exaggeration can discredit everything. And keep the town at the front, and let the movement shape the story around the promise and the place.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Make them your own; keep them short, exact and calm; keep a copy of everything.

8A — Information request (to the authorities).

Subject: Request for the permit and the limit record — [project].

"We, residents of [place], request the permit, the EIA, and the record of the protective limit and the government's decisions for [project] at [location]. [Contact.]"

8B — Objection in the EIA.

Subject: Objection — [project].

"We, residents of [place], object to [project]: [it breaches the protective limit; it destroys our town; the EIA understates the harm]. We ask that it be refused. [Attach evidence.]"

8C — Invoking the protective limit (to the government).

Subject: Keep the limit and your promise — [project].

"We, residents of [place], call on the government to keep the protective limit it drew, and its promise to our town, and to refuse [project]. To breach it would be to break your word, as the government finally would not at Horní Jiřetín. [Attach evidence.]"

8D — To a lawyer (court / EU law).

Subject: Challenge — [project].

"Our community faces [project], breaching a protective limit and destroying our town, on [a defective permit]. We've gathered [the limit, the EIA]. We ask your advice on challenging it in the courts and under EU environmental law. [Contact and evidence summary.]"

8E — To the European Commission (if EU law is breached).

Subject: Breach of EU environmental law — [project], Czechia.

"We report that [project] at [location] breaches [Natura 2000 / EU environmental law]: [specifics]. We ask the Commission to investigate. [Attach evidence.]"

8F — To the company / financiers.

Subject: Legal, political, and reputational risk in [project].

"We are the community affected by [project] at [location]. It requires a government to break a protective limit and demolish a town, and faces a national movement and legal challenge. This carries real risk. [Contact and evidence summary.]"

8G — Letter to the press.

Subject: [Town] moves to hold the line against [project].

"[Town] has stood for [750] years. Now [project] would dig it up for coal — breaking the promise that protected it. We can provide the town's story, the limit, photographs, and interviews. [Contact.]"

8H — Rallying the town and the nation.

Subject: We are the limits — here's how we hold the line.

"[Project] would demolish our town and break the government's promise. At Horní Jiřetín, a united town and a national movement — 'we are the limits' — held the line for twenty years, and the coal stays in the ground. If we unite and rouse the nation, we can too. Please join us. [Contact.]"

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

If you must move fast and lean, do these six things, in order:

1. **Establish the protective limit and the government's promise behind it.** That's your sharpest lever.
2. **Invoke the limit and demand the promise be kept (8C), and object in the EIA (8B).**
3. **Unite the town behind its leaders, refusing to be moved.**

4. **Build a national movement and use the climate frame (8H/8G) to raise the cost of breaking the promise.**

5. **Get a lawyer for the courts and EU law (8D/8E).**

6. **Sustain the pressure — and defend the line year after year.**

Even lean, those six invoke and defend the limit, unite the town, and rouse the nation — the Horní Jiřetín template.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

Czechia's tools are real, but a powerful coal industry can tilt the field, and you must plan for it.

When a government is tempted to break the limit. Make keeping the promise the easier, more honourable course — rouse the nation, invoke the guarantee, and raise the political cost of being the government that razed a town.

When the company never quits. A protective limit is a line to be defended, not a victory banked. Sustain the movement and the endurance across changing governments.

When it takes twenty years. Horní Jiřetín's win took two decades. Build for endurance, and hold the line each time the government must choose.

When EU law can help. Where a protected site or EU environmental law is engaged, use the courts and the European Commission to add weight beyond the national fight.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO'S CAPTURED

Czechia has real concerns about the closeness of the coal industry to energy and mining decisions, so this matters.

How to spot it. Pressure to breach a limit against the evidence; permits against the law; EIAs written for the proponent; benefits to the connected while a town faces erasure.

Who's supposed to guard against it. The **Supreme Audit Office** examines public money. Anti-corruption and prosecution bodies handle graft. The **courts and the European Commission** enforce the law. And Czechia's **press, environmental organisations, and national movements** have exposed captured decisions.

How to fight it safely. Document precisely and factually — the pressure to breach the limit, who benefits, what the law and the promise required — and keep clear the line between what you can prove and what you suspect. Route serious evidence to the Supreme Audit Office, the prosecutors, the courts, the European Commission, and trusted journalists rather than making accusations you can't back. Pair the exposure with the defence of the limit.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE

Don't run these steps one after another — run them together, over the long haul. The documents and the protective limit build your case; the promise aims it; a united town is the muscle; the courts, EU law, and the national movement press the case; the climate frame and the press raise the cost. Together they multiply. One at a time, they stall — and defend the line year after year.

Early on (weeks–months): establish the protective limit and the promise; object in the EIA; request the records; unite the town; begin the national movement.

In the thick of it (months–years): invoke and defend the limit; challenge a defective permit in the courts and under EU law; build the climate frame; open the national media front.

The long haul (years): hold the line across changing governments; make keeping the promise the easier course each time; sustain the movement and the endurance; hold the line for a project stopped, a limit held, a town saved, and delay.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Stopping a destructive project in Czechia can be done — a small North Bohemian town, facing literal erasure, held the mining limits for twenty years and kept the coal in the ground beneath it. Hold both truths. Czechia's distinctive power is real: where a government has drawn a protective limit — a promise to a community — a determined town, backed by endurance and a national movement, can hold the government to its own word, even against a powerful company and the lure of the coal, by making keeping the promise the politically easier and more honourable course. And the constraints are real: a protective limit is a promise a later government can break, and holding it took the better part of twenty years of relentless, united effort.

Here's the discipline that wins. Establish the protective limit and the government's promise behind it, and invoke it — framing a breach not as approving a mine but as breaking the state's word to a community. Unite the town behind its leaders, refusing to be moved, because no government wants to be the one that razed a living town. Build a national movement and use the climate frame to raise the cost of breaking the promise, and challenge a defective permit in the courts and under EU law. Above all, make keeping the promise the easier, more honourable course each time the government must choose — and sustain that pressure and endurance for years, defending the line as a line to be held, not a victory banked. Count a project stopped, a limit held, a town saved, and delay as wins. That's what Horní Jiřetín did — the protective limit, the united town, the national movement, and twenty years of endurance together. So can you.